Marketing Research Methods

Assignment 1

Research Design BLUEPRNT Framework

1. This is a group assignment. All work submitted must be entirely your own.
2. Exercises A and B asks you to build a complete BLUEPRNT research design for a consumer marketing scenario.
3. Exercise C asks you to critique a pre-built research design that contains deliberate errors.
4. Use the BLUEPRNT terminology precisely throughout. Confusing terms (e.g., using 'unit of analysis' to mean 'sample size') will cost marks.
5. **Submission format – Word or PDF document. Please ensure that the name of the document is appropriate.**
6. **Submission deadline – Sunday, 18th October 2026 EOD.**
7. The instructor reserves the right to request all the groups to make a presentation – either in class, or one-on-one.
8. **First page should contain the following:**

Submission Details

Name of Group members with Roll Numbers	
Group Number	
Submission Date	

Integrity Declaration: We confirm that the work submitted in this assignment is entirely our own. We have not copied from, collaborated with, or shared our responses with any other student/ group. We have not used any AI tool – including but not limited to ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, or any equivalent – to generate, draft, or substantially assist with any part of my answers. We understand that a violation of this declaration may result in a failing grade or disciplinary action as per the programme's academic integrity policy.

Signatures: _____ Date: _____

Exercise A: Build the Blueprint

HealthFirst Pharmacy Chain

HealthFirst is a chain of 85 pharmacies operating across 12 Tier 1 and Tier 2 Indian cities. Over the past six months, HealthFirst has noticed that its average transaction value per customer has declined by 14%, while footfall has remained stable. The CEO believes customers are buying their regular medications at HealthFirst but switching to online pharmacies (Tata 1mg, PharmEasy) for non-prescription health and wellness products, **where prices are lower and delivery is convenient**. She wants research to understand: whether her hypothesis is correct; which customer segments are most likely to be splitting purchases across channels; and what – if anything – would bring those non-prescription purchases back to HealthFirst.

YOUR TASK

For each BLUEPRNT component below, write one to three sentences specifying your design decision. Justifying it with reference to this specific scenario.

- Specifications that are correct but not connected to the HealthFirst context will receive partial credit only.
- Specifications without any justification would also receive partial credit.

Component	Your Specification and Justification
B – Background and Research Purpose	
L – Logic of Time	
U – Unit of Analysis	
E – Evidence Type	
P – Procedure for Data Collection	
R – Reach: Sampling Approach	
N – Numbers and Measurement	
T – Techniques of Analysis	

Exercise B

Two Blueprints – NourishGrain Packaged Atta

NourishGrain is a mid-market packaged atta (wheat flour) brand with strong distribution across Tier 2 and Tier 3 towns in three states: Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan. It sells exclusively through a traditional distribution chain – from the company to super stockists, then to distributors, then to kirana stores and small grocery outlets. Over the past two quarters, secondary sales (distributor to retailer) have declined by 11% in Tier 2 towns, while primary sales (company to distributor) have remained flat. This means inventory is building at the distributor level rather than moving through to retail. The brand manager has identified two competing hypotheses:

H1 – end-consumer demand has softened (households are buying less packaged atta or switching to loose flour or alternative grains);

H2 – retailers are preferring to stock competing brands that offer better trade margins or superior in-store visibility support. She wants research to determine which hypothesis is correct – and, if both are partially true, which deserves more urgent attention.

Important: This case is different from Exercises A in a critical structural way. Read the scenario carefully before attempting any part of this exercise.

Part 1 – Diagnostic Question (attempt this before starting BLUEPRNTs)

For each hypothesis, identify:

1. Which audience it belongs to;
2. Why that audience – and not the other – can answer it.
3. In 2–3 sentences, explain why the two hypotheses cannot be tested by a single research design.

Hypothesis	Audience it belongs to	Justification for the assignment
H1: End-consumer demand has softened – households are buying less packaged atta or switching to loose/alternative flour.		
H2: Retailers are preferring to stock competing brands – better trade margins and/or superior in-store visibility support are pulling.		

In a few sentences, explain why these two hypotheses cannot be tested by a single research design.

Part 2 – BLUEPRNT Design 1: End-Consumer Research

YOUR TASK

Design a research blueprint that addresses H1 – the consumer-side hypothesis. For each component, write one to three sentences specifying your design decision and justifying it with reference to this specific scenario. Pay particular attention to the population coverage challenge posed by a Tier 2 town consumer audience.

Component	Consumer Research – Specification and Justification
B – Background and Research Purpose	
L – Logic of Time	
U – Unit of Analysis	
E – Evidence Type	
P – Procedure for Data Collection	
R – Reach: Sampling Approach	
N – Numbers and Measurement	
T – Techniques of Analysis	

Part 3 – BLUEPRNT Design 2: Retailer / Trade Research

YOUR TASK

Design a research blueprint that addresses H2 – the retailer/trade hypothesis. For each component, write one to three sentences specifying your design decision and justifying it. This blueprint will require fundamentally different decisions from your consumer design – do not copy across. The unit of analysis, procedure, sampling frame, and evidence type will all need to reflect the trade channel context.

Component	Retailer/ Trade Research – Specification and Justification
B – Background and Research Purpose	
L – Logic of Time	
U – Unit of Analysis	
E – Evidence Type	
P – Procedure for Data Collection	
R – Reach: Sampling Approach	
N – Numbers and Measurement	
T – Techniques of Analysis	

Exercise C: Critique the Blueprint

QuickBite Food Delivery App Study

QuickBite is a food delivery startup operating in four Tier 1 cities. It has experienced a 20% decline in repeat orders from customers who placed their first order in the past three months (first-order to repeat-order conversion). The head of growth wants to understand why.
The research team has produced the following design blueprint:

Your Task:

1. For each BLUEPRNT component, identify the specific error(s) in the proposed specification.
2. Explain why each error is a problem – what will go wrong downstream if this specification is used?
3. Write a corrected specification for each component that is appropriate for this research question.

Component	Proposed Specification
B – Background and Research Purpose	Causal research design. We want to understand why customers are not reordering and recommend an app redesign that will fix the problem.
L – Logic of Time	Cross-sectional survey. We will collect data at one point in time to understand the issue.
U – Unit of Analysis	All QuickBite users.
E – Evidence Type	Primary quantitative data only. We will survey 300 new customers (those who ordered in the past 3 months) using a structured questionnaire.
P – Procedure for Data Collection	An online survey sent via push notification in the QuickBite app to all users who ordered in the past 3 months.
R – Reach: Sampling Approach	We will survey 300 customers. This is a large enough sample to get reliable results.
N – Numbers and Measurement	We will measure customer satisfaction using a single question: 'How satisfied are you with QuickBite? (1 = Very Dissatisfied, 5 = Very Satisfied).'
T – Techniques of Analysis	We will analyse the data and identify insights to share with the growth team.

Assessment Criteria

Criterion	What Is Being Assessed
Accuracy of BLUEPRNT specification	Each component correctly identified and appropriately specified for the specific business context; specifications are internally consistent across all 8 components.
Quality of justification	Each specification is accompanied by a clear, concise reason that connects the business scenario to the design decision – not just labelling the choice but explaining why it fits this context.
Error diagnosis	Each BLUEPRNT error correctly identified; the downstream consequence is accurately explained (not just flagged); the corrected specification is specific and actionable.
Precision of language	Uses the correct BLUEPRNT terminology throughout (e.g., does not confuse 'unit of analysis' with 'sample', does not conflate 'evidence type' with 'procedure'). Specifications are concise – within the 1–3 sentence limit.

Please note – All the criteria might not apply to all the 3 exercises.